UDDHAV AND THE ART OF MANAGING CONTRADICTIONS

DESPITE THE SETBACKS, THACKERAY'S SENA (UBT) STILL HAS THE SYMPATHY FACTOR GOING FOR IT. BUT IT'S AN UPHILL TASK, MANAGING THE ALLIANCE, WOOING NEW VOTER BLOCS AND KEEPING HIS CORE MARATHI VOTE INTACT

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A debilitating split in the party, a recalibration of political affiliations and a series of legal reverses. Things haven't been going well for Uddhav Thackeray since his partyman Eknath Shinde walked out of the Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi (MVA) government with 39 other MLAs and joined hands with the BJP in June 2022. Not only did it bring Thackeray's two-and-a-half-year chief ministership to an abrupt end, it left him and his faction—the Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) or Sena (UBT)—with little to bank on except the sympathy vote of the Marathi manoos and the possibility of gaining a foothold among the minorities.

Armed with this righteous plank, Uddhav has been on the warpath against the Shinde-led government, even alleging that the provisions of the interim budget were "pro-contractor and anti-people". The Sena (UBT) leader has also been training his guns on Prime Minister Narendra Modi's frequent visits to the state, suggesting the ruling coalition was getting anxious about its chances. This has, of course, raised the hackles of the BJP, with state rural development minister Girish Mahajan taunting Uddhav on February 28 about winning at least one Lok Sabha seat in Maharashtra, saying "a cat doesn't become a tiger just by wearing its skin".

Indeed, with the Opposition I.N.D.I.A. combine weakening at the national level and Shinde becoming entrenched in his role as Maharashtra CM, can Thackeray step up and take on the Marathi tiger mantle that was so much a part of his late father Balasaheb Thackeray's legacy? It will certainly not be easy. For one, the MVA, an alliance of convenience that came together to keep the BJP from forming a government, is a shadow of its former self, after the splits in two of its constituents—the Sena and the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP). Uddhav is also handicapped as Shinde has been handed the name and party symbol—allowing him to claim his faction as the 'real' Shiv Sena—and has consolidated his hold among the rural Marathas by promising them quotas as OBC (Other Backward Classes) Kunbis (peasants) and also giving them 10 per cent ring-fenced reservations in jobs and education.

THE SENA (UBT) STRATEGY

Every day, there is a rumour that another MLA from the Thackeray camp could switch to the Shinde faction. Uddhav loyalists, though, are hoping the setbacks will prove to be a blessing in disguise. A senior Sena (UBT) leader says they will try to capitalise on the 'betrayal' sentiment, highlighting how the BJP helped Shinde bring down the Thackeray-led government and was now handing him the Sena mantle. "The Marathi *manoos* are sentimen-